

Module 7: Migration Through History

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

Every migration debate happening today has happened before. Students pick one historical migration episode and one contemporary parallel and write a disciplined comparison — identifying what has genuinely changed and what only looks new — so they can evaluate present-day claims with historical depth.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Describe historical migration patterns in the chosen episode (UG 1)
- Compare past and present systems using an explicit framework (UG 2)
- Identify policy shifts and their consequences across the two periods (UG 3)

Graduate extension

Graduate students work from primary sources (period newspapers, laws, speeches, agency records) and frame the essay around continuity and rupture in migration regimes: which mechanisms persist and why (Grad 1).

Assignment steps

1. Choose a defensible pairing, e.g.: 1920s US quota laws and modern visa caps; Chinese Exclusion and contemporary travel bans; post-WWII displaced persons and today's protection system; Bracero guest workers and current temporary-labor visas; the Great Migration and internal climate displacement.
2. Research both cases — the historical one with at least two primary sources (graduate: four), the contemporary one with current data and policy documents.
3. Build an explicit comparison framework of 3–4 dimensions (e.g., who was excluded and how; the public rhetoric used; enforcement machinery; economic role of the migrants).
4. Write the essay AS a comparison throughout — not two summaries stapled together; every section must hold both cases.
5. Conclude with judgment: what does the historical case predict about the contemporary one, and where does the analogy break down?
6. Bring one primary source to seminar and present it in three minutes: what it is, who wrote it, what it reveals.

Deliverables & format

- Comparative essay, 1,800–2,200 words (graduate: 3,000+, primary-source based, continuity/rupture framing)
- Comparison framework table (one page)
- Annotated source list separating primary and secondary sources

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Historical accuracy and source quality 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: historical accuracy and source quality is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: historical accuracy and source quality is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: historical accuracy and source quality is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: historical accuracy and source quality is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Rigor of the comparison — parallel treatment throughout 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: rigor of the comparison — parallel treatment throughout goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: rigor of the comparison — parallel treatment throughout is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: rigor of the comparison — parallel treatment throughout is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: rigor of the comparison — parallel treatment throughout is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Insight on continuity vs. change, including where the analogy fails 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: insight on continuity vs. change, including where the analogy fails goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: insight on continuity vs. change, including where the analogy fails is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: insight on continuity vs. change, including where the analogy fails is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: insight on continuity vs. change, including where the analogy fails is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Writing and citation 15%	Communication is publication-ready: writing and citation is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: writing and citation is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: writing and citation is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: writing and citation is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.